

Chapter

The Future Lies in a Woman's Hands — Utterly Gentle, Utterly Fierce



Introduction: A Message from Mount Abu

At a gathering on women's empowerment in Mount Abu, Acharya Upendra ji had only fifteen minutes — though, as he himself says, his camps run "at least 10 to 15 hours at a stretch," and most of those who attend are women. So he poured "the ocean into a pitcher" and quickly set out many points: how India can become the world's guru, what a woman's real power is, which qualities Shri Krishna names

in women, and when and how today's woman should use her power.

"There is no bhajan, nothing else — it is pure knowledge, and from it transformation happens immediately. Today I will quickly give you a few glimpses of it."

1. Why India Has Not Become the World's Guru: The Ardhanarishvara State

Acharya ji begins with a popular aspiration of our times — "May India become the world's guru." His diagnosis is direct:

"Today, for India to become the world's guru, we have all the knowledge, all the powers. One thing is missing — India has not yet come into the Ardhanarishvara state. It is still a male-dominated society."

Ardhanarishvara — the form of Shiva in which half the body is Shiva and half is Shakti (Parvati); a perfect balance of the masculine and feminine principles. Acharya ji has seen this imbalance in spiritual institutions too:

"In their institutions I saw that there are women, they are seekers, they are everything — but they are not in the highest post."

"In our country, how many women have become Prime Minister? Few — one. So why not the rest?"

The path to India becoming the world's guru runs through the empowerment of women — it must attain the Ardhanarishvara form.

2. Not Equal — a Thousand Times More Powerful

Today woman is seeking equality with man. Acharya ji turns the question itself around:

"I am the one guru who says this: woman was never equal to man — she is at least a thousand times more powerful."

When was this power? In the bond between mother and child:

"Every man, every woman — whoever comes into the world — has come from some mother's womb. So when he comes from the mother's womb, her power would be not a thousand but many lakh times greater."

But a mother often uses that power only for pampering. Acharya ji recalls Chanakya's counsel:

**lālayet pañca varṣāṇi daśa varṣāṇi tāḍayet
prāpte tu ṣoḍaśe varṣe putraṁ mitravad ācaret**
"Pamper the child for five years, keep him under
discipline for the next ten, and when the sixteenth
year arrives, treat your son as a friend."

— Chanakya Niti

"Nurture him with affection for 5 years, fine; but for the next 10 years teach him — with discipline."

"Your power was a thousandfold then; that was when it had to be used. It is from that very society that someone becomes a thief, a goon, a bandit, a rapist."

The right time for a woman's thousandfold power is childhood — that is the chance to shape a child.

3. Only One Who Keeps Brahmacharya Can Protect

Sisters celebrate Raksha Bandhan and Bhai Dooj, and expect that their brother will protect them. Acharya ji adds a condition:

"But only that brother will be able to protect who himself observes brahmacharya. Because... know this for certain — one who troubles some other woman will not be able to protect us."

He gives an example from the Ramayana:

"Mother Sita too was abducted. She went to Lanka, to Ravana, but she remained protected. Why? Because here Rama was, until then, like a brahmachari; he had the power of his tapasya. And she too had power — she had her own pativrata dharma as well."

The power to protect comes from self-restraint and austerity — the protector's own character is his strength.

4. Without Understanding the Mother, the Guru Cannot Be Understood

Acharya ji turns to the subject of the mother:

"Until you understand a mother, you will never understand the guru. Because we call the guru 'Guru Mauli'; the guru is called 'Guru Mata'."

Mauli — Marathi for "mother"; in Maharashtra, Sant Dnyaneshwar is lovingly called "Dnyaneshwar Mauli."

5. The Masculine and Feminine Principles Within Everyone

From here Acharya ji makes a deep spiritual point:

"Inside every single person — whether the outer body is a man's or a woman's makes no difference — both principles are present within."

"If you are to attain liberation, if you are to attain moksha, then both principles within — masculine and feminine — must come into balance in you. So sometimes you must know how to be stern, sometimes pure love — both must be there."

Compassion, love, forgiveness — these are a woman's qualities, and greatness comes from them:

"A guru too is called a guru only when the feminine principles are greater within him — whatever the body, even a man's."

And so his message to women is a reassuring one:

"Women, don't you already have all of that within you — compassion, love, forgiveness, charity? ... So for you it is very very easy to get moksha. But where does the problem come?"

Moksha needs a balance of the masculine and feminine within — and a woman already has half the path.

6. Seven Divine Qualities of Women in the Gita

To explain that "problem," Acharya ji draws on the tenth chapter of the Bhagavad Gita, where Shri Krishna describes his glories:

mṛtyuḥ sarva-haraś cāham udbhavaś ca
bhaviṣyatām
kīrtiḥ śrīr vāk ca nārīṇāṁ smṛtir medhā dhṛtiḥ
kṣamā

"I am all-devouring death and the origin of all that
is yet to be; and among women I am fame,
prosperity (shri), speech (vak), memory,
intelligence, steadfastness and forgiveness."
— Bhagavad Gita 10.34

"In all these qualities, I am present. Now it is very
important to understand what I am present in, and
what I (as a woman) do."

Acharya ji opens up these qualities one by one.

7. Shri: The Griha-Lakshmi and Lakshmi's Three Arrivals

"Shri means Lakshmi — divine wealth should be abundant within me."

Why is a daughter-in-law called "Griha-Lakshmi" (the Lakshmi of the home)?

"We don't say a Griha-Saraswati has come, or a Griha-Kali has come. No — a Griha-Lakshmi has come. And that Lakshmi does not mean only outer wealth. Actually within her too — some love, an atmosphere of peace will come into the home."

And as soon as a woman becomes a mother, a divine feeling awakens in her by itself:

"As soon as a woman becomes a mother, that feeling of the Supreme arises in her by itself, without fail, in an instant. By then she has not even seen what her son's body or appearance is like — dark or fair... Automatically that love begins to work from the principle of the Self."

Then, citing the Devi Purana, Acharya ji explains that the real Lakshmi comes into a home three times:

- **As the mother:** "Until I properly accept her as mother — meaning, I don't listen to all she says — I don't understand her love either." She may not know the world's latest things, "and we say — reject her advice sometimes. So Shri does not come into your home much."
- **As the daughter-in-law:** "In the home where the daughter-in-law who has come is not respected, Shri leaves once again."
- **As the daughter:** "People say, 'Oh dear, it would have been better if it were a boy.' Remember, in that very home Shri is mostly absent. And if Shri comes, it is not enjoyed; if it is enjoyed, its joy is not felt."

Respecting woman in all three forms — mother, daughter-in-law and daughter — is what keeps Lakshmi in the home.

8. Vak: Utterly Gentle, Utterly Fierce

The second quality is **vak** — speech. Everyone agrees a woman's speech should be loving and compassionate. But Acharya ji says that is not enough:

"It is said of Goddess Durga — 'utterly gentle, utterly fierce' is her form. Read the Durga Saptashati."

The problem is that these two forms appear in the wrong places:

"The fierce form often comes out in front of the husband, and the gentle form comes out outside — however much injustice happens outside, she bears it. Whereas that is not what she was to do."

"Her utterly gentle form should have been at home. And outside, where injustice is happening — whether in the office or anywhere outside — ... there she must be utterly fierce too. This has to be learned."

The order of the three episodes of the Durga Saptashati says the same — Mahakali in the first, Mahalakshmi in the middle, Mahasaraswati in the last:

"So Kali is very very essential."

Acharya ji also makes the practical meaning of vak clear:

"Somewhere you will have to be firm. The mother-in-law keeps speaking and speaking — how long will you listen? You have to set your boundaries."

"The image you build in your in-laws' home in the first one or two years — that will be there forever."

Gentleness is for the home, fierceness is for injustice — and your boundaries must be set at the very start.

9. Smriti, Dhriti, Medha: The Qualities of Vedanta Come Naturally to Women

Acharya ji explains the next three qualities together:

- **Smriti** — "Smriti means memory."
- **Dhriti** — "Dhriti means the power of dharana — holding on something for very long time." This is the same **dharana** that comes in Ashtanga Yoga — yama, niyama, asana, pranayama, pratyahara, dharana, dhyana, samadhi.
- **Medha** — after an austerity of twelve years of brahmacharya, the vital fluids become **ojas** and then radiance, whether in a man or a woman; after that comes medha: "Once you heard something, even by chance, and then at the right time you produce it as it is — this is called the power of medha."

"In spirituality, in Vedanta, all these qualities are essential. So Shri Krishna says — I have given these to women in abundance; in the woman who has these, I, the Supreme, am manifest in her form."

Men have to develop this power — and here Acharya ji gives light-hearted examples:

"'Please bring the vegetables' — and on the way back he says, 'I forgot.' ... And a woman will hold right there in her memory what her sister-in-law said to her 20 years ago."

"So this is the quality the woman has."

But a problem hides in this very quality. As the scriptures put it:

"The best person is one who actually forgets a matter in 5 minutes. Which matter? Not the guru's words — those are not to be forgotten; those are to be held for a lifetime."

"The middling person is one who forgets in a week. And the lowest person is one who can bring up even what happened after 1857 to this day. That is why quarrels keep happening."

"So the qualities needed to learn Vedanta — women have them. Only thing — Shri Krishna says this is to be remembered, and this is to be forgotten."

Memory and steadfastness are for holding on to knowledge, not for carrying old grievances.

10. Forgiveness — but With Boundaries

"It is said that woman is forgiving. But it is not said to forgive just anyone. In some places a Durga-like form is necessary for her."

"Set your boundaries clear before time. If you don't, there will be a big problem in the family."

11. Choosing a Life Partner: Why Intuition Gets Lost

Acharya ji gives a simple example — a train compartment, every window seat taken by men, and a journey of only twenty minutes:

"Even then a woman has so much intuition power that — this one looks a bit off, that one seems a bit like a goon. She has that intuitive power, and ... she can go and sit where someone looks decent."

"If this power is within you, where does it go when choosing a life partner?"

He explains the reason through the four levels of a human being — body, mind, intellect and Self:

"Men live at the level of the body and at the level of the intellect. Intellectual — they are scientists, ... they will keep applying logic every time. This is how men are made."

"She will work at the level of the mind — very emotion-driven. And the other is directly at the level of the Self — as when she becomes a mother, ... then completely emotion-driven, and completely free."

He makes clear this is not belittling anyone — "it is not that they have no intellect... or that men have no mind at all." But being emotion-driven carries a risk:

"She has to take care while selecting the partner also. He can manipulate you with his intellect, can create trouble."

The intuition that stays alert on a twenty-minute journey must stay alert when choosing a companion for life.

12. The True Meaning of Pativrata Dharma

Acharya ji challenges a deeply rooted belief:

"It has settled into our sanskaras that in everything you simply bear injustice. That is not pativrata dharma."

"A woman who brings her husband a glass of liquor is not called pativrata. She should be the one who makes him give up liquor. For that she can fight as much as she wants. That much Kali-power should come into her."

According to him, the description of this dharma was altered over time:

"From the time of the British and the Mughals, some changes were made in the scriptures to weaken women. ... That description of pativrata dharma has been somewhat diluted, changed."

"It is said: when the husband before you is like Shiva, then you are to become like Parvati. Otherwise, with the power of pativrata he will change, yes — but for whom should I waste that much time? This too you have to understand — when to quit, when to stop."

Pativrata does not mean bearing injustice; it means bringing the husband back to the right path — and having the discernment to know when to stop.

13. Kali, Lakshmi, Saraswati — All Three Forms Deserve Respect

"Perhaps I am one of the guru who — when women come, I tell them just one thing — even a woman who wears powder and lipstick can attain moksha. Otherwise, take down the photo of Lakshmi ji."

"It is not only the Saraswati form. That is one form, one aspect; the others are there too, so they should be respected as well."

"It is Kali Yuga now — nothing will work without wealth. 'Dharmasya mulam arthah.'"

Dharmasya mulam arthah — a Chanakya Sutra: the root of dharma is artha (wealth). Empowerment needs three powers, and each is linked with one of the three goddesses:

"Iccha shakti (the power of will), kriya shakti (the power of action), jnana shakti (the power of knowledge) — all three of them are equally important. Each of them is one of — Mahakali, Mahalakshmi, Mahasaraswati."

The power of Mahakali means protection:

"The power of Mahakali — physical protection. We say one should learn karate — so start, that is the basic level. A higher protection than that is spiritual power. If you have it, the enemy does not even look at you with an evil eye."

The same applies to dress and profession. Everyone in the gathering was dressed in white — the Saraswati form. Acharya ji says:

"Some woman says she wants to become a police inspector; someone is a politician ... that is hardly wrong work. In that too you should be able to see the Kali form of the Goddess."

"Someone becomes a business woman, then ... wealth — that too is not wrong at all; it carries the form of Lakshmi. And someone is Saraswati — the form of knowledge. So all three — we keep no such ban or restriction or anything like that."

Mahakali's protection, Mahalakshmi's prosperity, Mahasaraswati's knowledge — an empowered woman embraces all three.

14. Health: Speech That Gets Stuck Becomes Disease

On health, Acharya ji shares the experience of his healing camps:

"If you don't express, you get thyroid. I have studied this in India — because we hold healing camps — so maximum, the ladies in India, they get thyroid. The reason is — the voice gets stuck right here; she does not speak."

"Second, she develops a fear of the unknown — at home this one will say this, that one will say that — and then knee pain comes. ... That is a research that we have done."

But the solution is not shouting either:

"Express — and they started doing it by shouting! ... Thyroid won't come, but a heart problem will come, or something with BP. You have to say it, but in a proper tone."

Don't suppress what is in your heart, and don't shout it either — express it in a proper tone.

15. No Future Without Knowing History

"If you go to a doctor, what does he ask first? He takes your medical history. ... Without it, no diagnosis is even possible."

"So if women's empowerment is to happen in this country, what happened to women before — what happened in 2000 years? How many atrocities happened? Why did they happen? All of that will have to be looked at."

16. The Guru Should Be Like a Mother: Jupiter Exalted in Cancer

Returning to becoming the world's guru, Acharya ji offers a beautiful hint from astrology:

"In which sign is Guru (Jupiter) exalted? ... It is exalted in Karka (Cancer). Karka is the sign of the Moon; the Moon is the form of the mother. Only the teacher who can teach like a mother — only then will he be (a guru)."

"A mother never asks her child for any fee. In Dhanu (Sagittarius) it is in its own sign, but that is a fire sign — stern; people don't like that kind of teacher. ... In Meena (Pisces) it is emotional — people don't like that much either. It should be like a mother."

And from here a chain forms — mother, guru and nation:

"Until you understand a mother, you cannot understand the guru, cannot understand the Guru-Ma. Until you understand the Guru-Ma, you cannot understand Bharat Mata."

"Are we ready to understand them (the rest of the world) like a mother? Not yet."

To become the world's guru, India needs a mother's heart — one that can understand the whole world as its own child.

17. No One Will Give You Power — You Must Claim It Yourself

"We do say — 'yatra nāryas tu pūjyante ramante tatra devatāḥ.' Fine, but who will do the worship? There must be some priest. Kali Yuga is the rule of the asuras."

Where women are worshipped, there the gods rejoice — this is a famous verse of the Manusmriti. Acharya ji gives its meaning for Kali Yuga:

"So worship is given only to the one who is powerful. There, Chanda-Munda, Shumbha-Nishumbha — no one's rule prevails. Those qualities will have to be brought in."

Chanda-Munda and Shumbha-Nishumbha — the asuras of the Durga Saptashati whom the Goddess slew.

18. What Kind of Guru Women's Empowerment Needs

At the end, Acharya ji puts the question to the gathering itself — what kind of guru does women's empowerment need?

"He should have a woman's mind within him. But if there is only a woman's mind, then they are taken advantage of, as they say. So a little masculine too — they will have to become like the Ardhanarishvara form — a little stern too."

"Such a guru can instil that power in you who himself understands a woman's pain, lives it, sees it — he feels that — at the same time the masculine principle ... must be equally present within him."

And he closes on the same thread with which this chapter began:

"I am saying that both forms — utterly gentle, utterly fierce — must be there."

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1** Only one thing is missing for India to become the world's guru — the Ardhanarishvara state. It will come only through women's empowerment.
- 2** Woman is not equal to man but at least a thousand times more powerful — and the right time for that power is a child's childhood: "lālayet pañca varṣāṇi daśa varṣāṇi tāḍayet."
- 3** Only one established in brahmacharya and austerity can protect — as Sita was protected by Rama's tapasya and her own pativrata dharma.
- 4** Everyone has masculine and feminine principles within; moksha needs both in balance. A woman already has compassion, love and forgiveness — "for you it is very very easy to get moksha."
- 5** According to Gita 10.34, the Lord Himself manifests in woman as shri, vak, smriti, medha, dhriti and kshama.

- 6** Lakshmi comes into a home three times — as mother, daughter-in-law and daughter; where they are not respected, Shri does not stay.
- 7** Utterly gentle, utterly fierce: gentleness at home, fierceness before injustice — and "set your boundaries clear before time."
- 8** Memory and steadfastness are for holding on to knowledge, not for carrying old grievances.
- 9** Don't lose your intuition when choosing a life partner — beware of being manipulated by intellect while swept along by emotion.
- 10** Pativrata dharma does not mean bearing injustice; it means turning the husband back from the wrong path — and knowing "when to quit, when to stop."
- 11** Mahakali, Mahalakshmi, Mahasaraswati — protection, prosperity and knowledge — all three forms deserve respect. Police inspector, business woman, seeker of knowledge — no path is wrong.
- 12** Suppressing emotions brings disease, and so does shouting; express them in a proper tone.

13 No one will give you power — in Kali Yuga, worship goes only to the one who is powerful.

The future lies in a woman's hands — but only when she recognises her thousandfold power, uses it at the right time, and awakens all three forms of the Goddess within her: utterly gentle for the home, utterly fierce against injustice.